



THE WORLD OF BEES TODAY

Dear friends... and especially you, our youngest readers!

Today we begin this simple column, which will accompany us every two weeks as we discover a truly extraordinary world: the world of bees.

With simple words, curiosities and short stories, we will get to know these precious insects better, understand how they live, how they work together and how important they are for nature and for all of us.

Of course, this column also wants to be a space open to all of you: your stories, experiences and photographs will be welcome, whether they are about nature in general or more closely connected with bees, hives, flowers and the environment around them.

You can also send us reports about environmental degradation, difficulties or problems affecting hives, observations about the health of bees and, more generally, anything that can help us better understand what is happening in the local area.

Every testimony, photograph or report can become a small but useful contribution to understanding problems, raising awareness and, where possible, helping together to improve things and protect bees and their environment.

With our warmest greetings, we look forward to seeing you in the next issue, to continue this small journey together through the wonderful world of bees.



A closer look

When a bee lands on a flower, it may look still. In fact, it is at work: its antennae explore, its legs find support and its tongue reaches the nectar. Grains of pollen stick to its hairy body. Some will end up on another flower. Others will return to the hive, gathered in the small baskets on the hind legs. A single visit already tells two stories: feeding the colony and sustaining plant life.

THE WORD



A home full of life

A hive is a colony, a large family living together. There is a queen that lays eggs. There are thousands of worker bees that feed the young, build the comb, clean, defend and forage. Drones are the males and play a role in reproduction. The comb cells hold developing bees and food stores. Look closely and what seems like disorder becomes collective work.

Brood: the term for eggs, larvae and bees that are still developing.

DID YOU KNOW?



A day outside

A bee leaves the hive when conditions allow. It searches for flowers, gathers nectar and pollen, then returns. If it finds a good food source, it can tell its nestmates where to look through movements on the comb. The journey does not follow a clock: it depends on light, weather and flowering. And among many similar entrances, the bee can still find its own hive.

DID YOU KNOW?



Much more than honey

On a flower, a bee is looking for food. At the same time, it carries pollen to other flowers of the same species: this is pollination. In this way many plants can form seeds and fruits. Not all plants depend on bees, and bees are not the only pollinators: bumblebees, butterflies, flies and other animals also take part. Protecting pollinators means making room for a web of life much larger than our jar of honey.

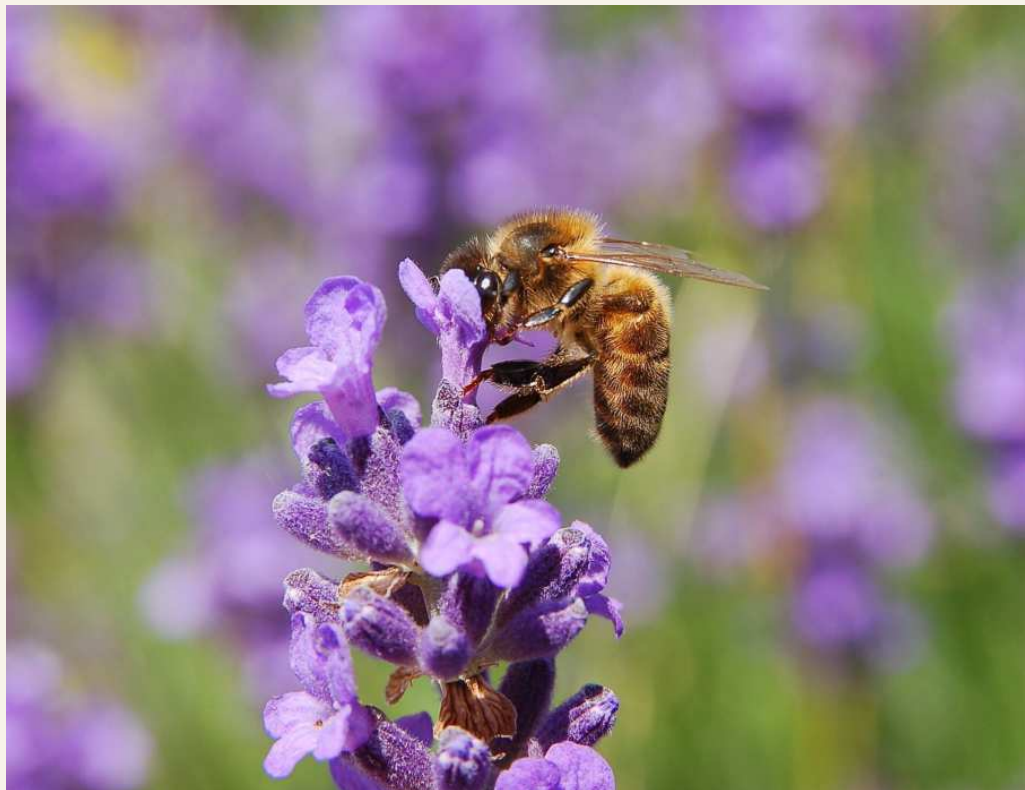
How are they doing today?

One season does not tell the story of every hive.

Bees do not all face the same situation. One colony may thrive in a flower-rich place and struggle elsewhere. Honey, moreover, tells only part of the story. The National Honey Observatory report on the 2025 season describes Italian production recovering, but with major differences from area to area, and market difficulties still present. Behind the national average are very different territories, seasons and kinds of work.

THE FIGURE, WITH THE YEAR

2025 season: production recovering, with strong territorial variability. Source: National Honey Observatory, report published in 2026.



When they are doing well

A meadow that flowers for a long time offers food at different moments. A water source, a varied environment and a hive followed with care help the colony face the season. "Doing well" does not mean never having problems. It means being able to rely on resources and on a beekeeper who can notice the signs and act when needed. Good news is often made of regular, patient gestures.

WARNING SIGN



When flowers are scarce

Imagine arriving at a market and finding the shelves empty. For a bee, this can happen when flowering ends early or an environment offers few flowers. Persistent rain can also prevent it from flying on the right days. A colony has stores, but not endless ones. There is no single cause: local conditions, bee health and the course of the season all interact.

WARNING SIGN

This scene represents a local condition; by itself it does not prove a loss of hives.

WORTH OBSERVING



IN OUR TERRITORY

**Every flowering has
its own time.**

If a plant flowers earlier than usual, bees may find it at a different moment than expected. If it rains for days during flowering, nectar can remain out of reach. Heat and drought can reduce available resources. A changing climate increases pressure on plants, bees and beekeepers, but every territory has its own story. Understanding it requires repeated observations, not a single photograph.

SOURCE



A difficult guest

Varroa is a small mite that lives at the expense of bees and reproduces in the cells where young bees develop. It can weaken the colony and encourage the spread of viruses. For this reason, beekeepers monitor the parasite and apply the prescribed measures to limit it. In a close-up photograph Varroa looks enormous; in reality it measures only a few millimetres.

Ministry of Health, "Varroatosis" fact sheet. Control requires expertise and continuity.

LOOK CAREFULLY



Who opens the hive

Before lifting a comb, the beekeeper observes. What is activity like at the entrance? Are there stores? Is the queen laying? Are young bees developing? Every inspection should have a reason. Opening the hive too often disturbs the colony; never looking can mean missing an important sign. Experience also means knowing when to close it again and let the bees work.

A comb in the beekeeper's hand is a page to be read, not only honey to be harvested.

IN THE REPORT

A job shaped by the seasons

Observe, prepare, wait.

A beekeeper prepares in advance, but cannot order the sun to shine or stop the rain. Equipment is moved, hive health is checked, materials and labour are paid for even when the harvest is poor. CREA's Honey Cost report, referring to 2023-2024 and published in 2026, studies the costs and sustainability of beekeeping businesses. Behind every jar are choices, expertise and risks.

IN THE REPORT

THE WORD



Many lands, many honeys

Italian beekeeping stretches across plains, hills, woods and mountains. The plants change, flowering periods change and the honeys change. Some beekeepers keep their hives in the same place; others move them to follow the blooms: this practice is called migratory beekeeping. That is also why two harvests of the same type of honey can have different nuances. The territory enters the jar, but first it entered the flight of the bees.

THE WORD



FROM OUR PROJECT

Honey begins with flowers

Bees collect nectar and carry it back to the hive. There they transform it and store it in the cells as food. Only honey that can be taken without compromising the colony's needs reaches us. Colour, aroma and texture vary with botanical origin and over time. Crystallised honey has not gone bad: crystallisation is a natural process.

LOOK CAREFULLY



Pollen baskets

Watch a bee leaving a flower: on its hind legs it may carry two coloured pellets. They are loads of pollen gathered and packed together during flight. Their colours change depending on the flowers visited. In the hive, pollen is an important resource for feeding the colony, especially when new bees are growing. Our interest in this product comes after its role in the life of the hive.

The two pellets on the legs can have different shades if the bee has visited different flowers.



Pollen enters the comb

Some of the collected pollen is placed in the cells. The bees work it together with other substances from the hive: this is what we call bee bread. In the comb it is not a product "for display", but a food store for the family. Cells with different colours also tell the story of the variety of flowers visited. An authentic photograph of this detail is worth more than many definitions.



Propolis in the hive

Bees collect resinous substances from plants and work them until they become propolis. Among other things, they use it to seal small gaps and protect the internal environment of the hive. It is sticky, fragrant and changes appearance depending on the plants it comes from. Only after understanding what it means to bees can we look at preparations made by people without attributing miraculous powers to them.

In the comb, a gap sealed with propolis is a small act of home maintenance.

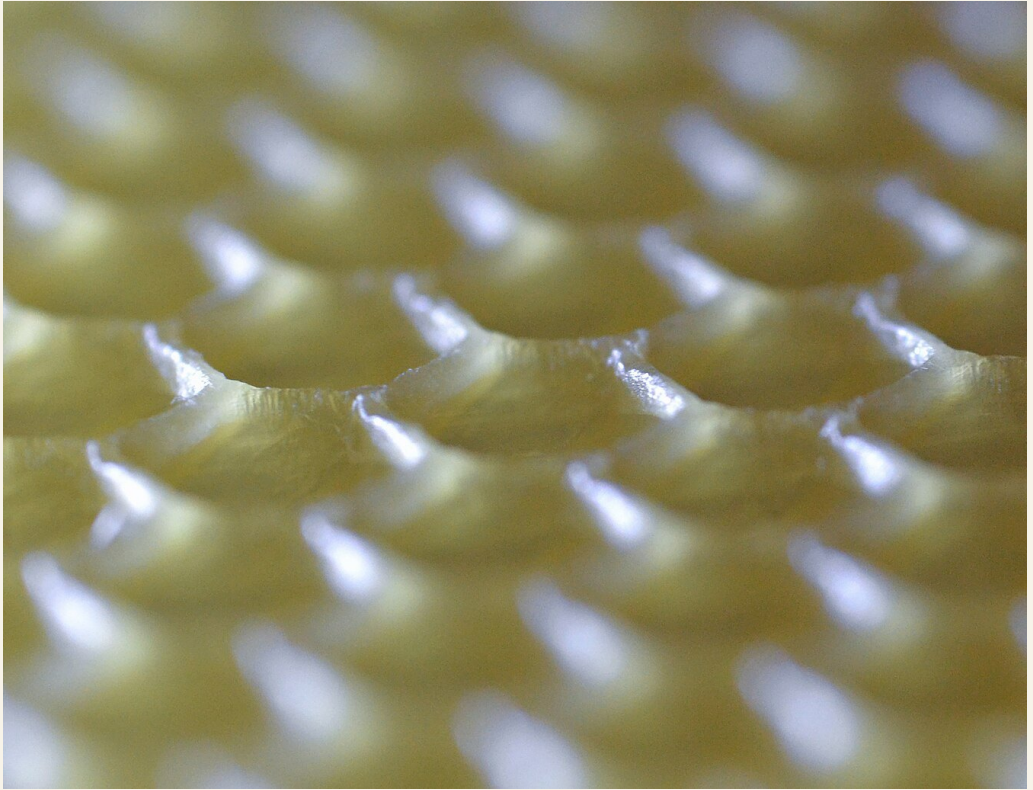
LOOK CAREFULLY



Food for queens

Royal jelly is produced by young worker bees. It feeds larvae in their early stages and the queen throughout her life. Its story takes us to the heart of the colony: caring for new generations. When talking about products intended for people, it is important to keep this natural function separate from health claims, which require specific evidence.

A queen cell has a different shape from ordinary comb cells.



A house made of wax

Worker bees produce wax and use it to build cells. The comb is light, but provides space for development, storing pollen and holding honey. Up close, the hexagons look like a precise design. Yet they are the result of the work of many bees, side by side. Before becoming a candle or another object, wax was the structure of their home.

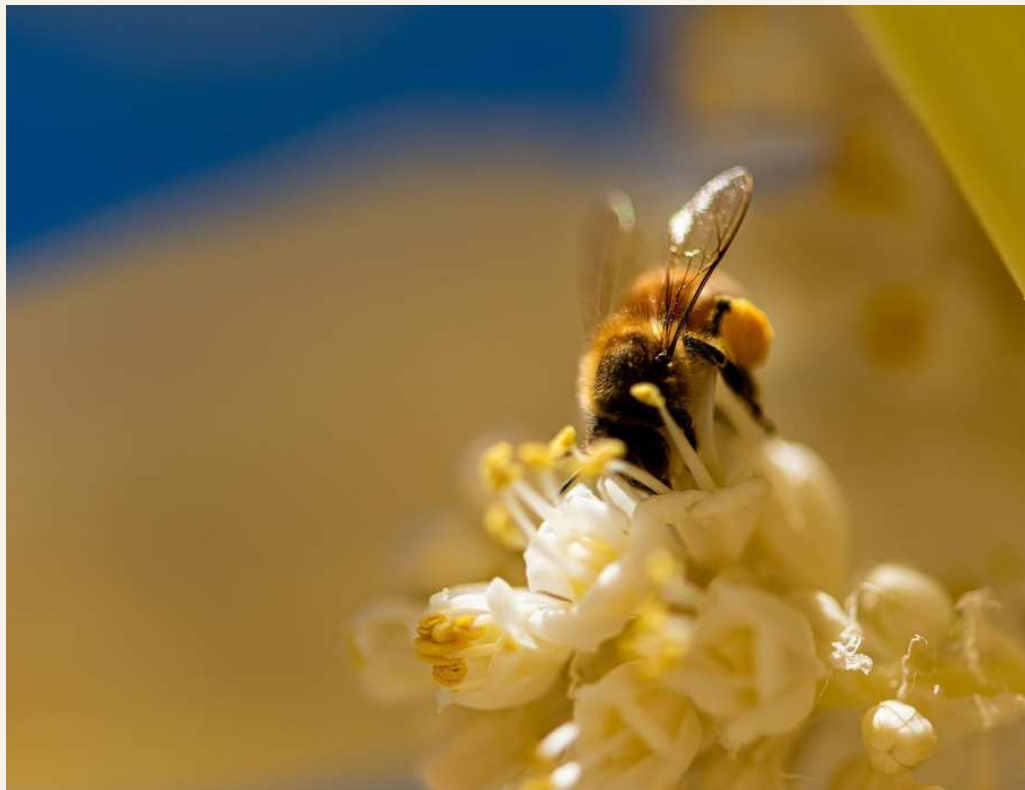
REMEMBER



Why does a bee sting?

The sting is used mainly for defence. Worker bees can use it when they perceive a threat to themselves or the colony. A sting can cause serious reactions in sensitive people: it is wise to keep calm and keep some distance near hives. Bee venom is studied and appears in some dedicated formulations, but that does not justify promises of cures. Here we begin with its role for the bee.

If someone has significant symptoms after a sting, seek medical help immediately.



Bees close to us

You do not need a long journey to meet a bee. It may be in a vegetable garden, a park or on a flower-filled balcony. Watching it closely without touching it is already a way to get to know it. Not every yellow-and-black insect is a bee; and not all bees live in hives managed by people. The world of pollinators is more diverse than it appears.

TRY OBSERVING



A useful gesture

Choose plants that flower at different times. Where possible, leave a few less tidy corners. If you provide water, use a shallow container with stones where insects can land. Always follow the directions for plant treatments. If you encounter a swarm, avoid improvised action and contact a beekeeper or the competent local service. Small choices, repeated over time, can change a place.

TRY OBSERVING

Which flowers are visited in your neighbourhood? Note the month and take photos without disturbing them.

SEND US YOUR STORY



The territory tells its story

A flowering rediscovered, a meadow cut at the wrong time, a beekeeper at work: these are stories worth noticing. This page opens a space for readers. A useful report states the place, the date and what was observed. A photograph helps, but is not enough to establish the cause of a die-off or diagnose a hive problem. Testimonies will be checked before publication.

SEND US YOUR STORY

Your questions

Every question is an invitation to observe more closely.

Do bees sleep? They have periods of rest. Why do they return to exactly the right home? They use the sun, smells and landmarks. Do they all sting? No: drones have no sting, and many bees do not sting unless disturbed. How long does a worker bee live? It depends on the time of year and the work it does. The simplest questions are often the ones that open the best stories.

Galena delle Api



INTEGRATED ALVEOTHERAPY · GALENA DELLE API

In Castel d'Ario, Galena delle Api is a place to get closer to the world of the hive. The guiding idea is Integrated Alveotherapy: getting to know bees, observing what they produce and living an experience through dedicated systems. Here you can also encounter systems designed to accompany the discovery of aromas linked to the hive. The route invites you to slow down, observe and listen: every product and every object becomes an opportunity to return to the story of the bees.

A REAL PLACE

From the hive to people



GALENA DELLE API · CASTEL D'ARIO

After seeing how bees collect, build and protect the colony, hive products take on a different meaning. Honey, pollen, propolis and wax tell different stories. At Galena you can also discover preparations and dedicated product lines, including the Bee Venom Line. The story always begins with the bee: an object on a shelf becomes interesting when we know which action of the bee it comes from.

TWO SEASONS / ONE STORY

The hive all year round



SPRING / SUMMER AUTUMN / WINTER

In spring and summer, the experience can move closer to real hives in the natural environment. In autumn and winter, it continues inside Galena delle Api through dedicated systems. These are two ways of meeting the same story, under different conditions and in different ways. The hive experience throughout the year is an invitation to knowledge, observation and respect for bees.



The two experiences belong to the same project and follow the rhythm of the seasons.

TWO SEASONS



Something bigger

A bee on a flower seems like a tiny scene. But around it there is a territory, the work of a beekeeper, plants that provide food for other animals and people capable of making thoughtful choices. We cannot solve everything with a single gesture. But we can learn to look, recognise real problems and nurture what works. The story of bees also concerns the landscape we share.

See you soon, and goodbye until the next edition!

This issue ends, but the journey continues. There are still stories to tell, photographs to observe and questions to ask. You may even find one of your own images or testimonies in the next issue. Write to us: photos, reports, ideas and suggestions are welcome.

LA FABBRICA DELLE API

www.lafabbricadelleapi.it

althea12830@gmail.com · WhatsApp 334 8476020



DISCOVER THE NEW
EDITIONS